DEI is something of a mission at Axis Bank as well, where women constituted 25.7 per cent of the total employees in 2022-23. However, realising that a majority of these women held junior level positions, with the representation healthy in HR and communications roles but scanty in the finance, sales and technology divisions, the bank is making a conscious move towards "inclusion in every team". And so, the bank's MD & CEO Amitabh Chaudhry sent out an e-mail to all employees on Women's Day, enjoining that "I [also] invite all managers to actively mentor women in your teams. My own experience as a mentor to women leaders is that this process does not just build the women employee and drive her success, it equally transforms us as leaders.... I am certain that I will have your support in ensuring that there are women in every team".

To implement this vision, the bank's DEI Council is working in mission mode. Regular sessions are conducted with team managers across functions that have low or no diversity in their teams, and support and guidance extended in their journey to achieve inclusion. "The idea," says Harish Iyer, the DEI head at the bank, "is to make sure that inclusion does not remain an HR initiative but a business one, led by every manager, ensuring that every team becomes diverse. We want to be able to say that in every decision and at every seat at the table, there is a woman involved."

THE HIRING REVOLUTION

Typically, companies in India embark on their journey towards a more inclusive workplace by realigning their hiring strategies. Consulting and auditing firm Deloitte, for instance, ensures that women are hired across roles and hierarchies by incentivising its talent acquisition consultants. They are mandated to ensure that they receive an equal proportion of women's resumes for every position. And



AXIS BANK Moving consciously towards "inclusion in every team", regular sessions are conducted with managers of teams that have low diversity

HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- From 5 per cent a decade ago, women now occupy 20 per cent of board positions in NSE-listed companies; 45 per cent of these companies have more than one woman director on their boards
- Overall, the share of working women has increased to 37 per cent in FY23 from 23.3 per cent in FY18 (Periodic Labour Force Survey Report 2022-23)
- Whether in hiring or retaining talent, Indian firms are going all-out to attain their DEI objectives
- Companies are changing hiring strategies to include more women and trans people, with an emphasis on skills over experience
- To help women balance work and life, corporates are launching initiatives such as childcare support, hybrid/flexible working
- They are devising special policies and professional development programmes to ensure the advancement of women in the workplace and training them for leadership roles